

CHAPTER 5

FOES AND ENCOUNTERS



NPCs IN THE IRONLANDS

An NPC (non-player character/creature) is anyone who inhabits your version of the Ironlands other than your character and those portrayed by your fellow players. They can be a person, being or creature. You will roleplay your interactions with NPCs, and make moves when you attempt to influence them, aid them, gain their help, or act against them.

This chapter includes a variety of sample NPCs, organized by category.

- The **Ironlanders** are the humans who have settled these lands.
- The **Firstborn** are beings who walked the Ironlands uncountable years before humans arrived.
- **Animals** are common creatures.
- **Beasts** are monstrous creatures of unusual size and cunning.
- **Horrors** are supernatural beings.

These NPCs are a starting place. Use what fits your version of the Ironlands, keeping in mind the choices you made when you defined the characteristics of your setting in the previous chapter. If your world is entirely human-centric, ignore any fantastical NPCs. If you want to boost the fantasy in your campaign, you can emphasize the unreal or monstrous.

Use what you like. Discard what you don't. Create what is missing. It's your world.

COMPONENTS OF AN NPC

Because gameplay in *Ironsworn* is centered on the abilities and actions of your character, NPCs are primarily represented through your fiction rather than mechanics. They don't have stats, assets, or tracks. Instead, the sample NPCs in this chapter include some broad details to help guide their actions and the threat they pose in combat.

When you interact with an NPC, envision their personality and motivations. A brutish character leverages their strength, or attempts to bully and intimidate. A sly character acts through manipulation or trickery. A noble character behaves according to their sense of honor. An animal, depending on its disposition, may attack when threatened or may run away. A supernatural being may act with mindless malice and hate for the living, or may have more complex needs. When you are unsure of an NPC's traits or next action, *Ask the Oracle*. Then, envision what they do and make moves to aid or oppose them as appropriate.

RANK

NPCs have a single mechanical attribute, their rank. From this, their ability to resist and inflict harm (page 19) in combat is derived, as follows:

Rank	Type	Progress	Harm
Troublesome	Common enemies	3 progress per harm	Inflicts 1 harm
Dangerous	Capable fighters and deadly creatures	2 progress per harm	Inflicts 2 harm
Formidable	Exceptional fighters and mighty creatures	1 progress per harm	Inflicts 3 harm
Extreme	Foes of overwhelming skill or power	2 ticks per harm	Inflicts 4 harm
Epic	Legendary foes of mythic power	1 tick per harm	Inflicts 5 harm

When you engage a foe in combat, give them a standard progress track (10 boxes). When you *Strike* or *Clash* and inflict harm, mark progress for each point of harm based on the foe's rank. For example, you mark 2 ticks for each point of harm inflicted on an extreme foe, and 2 progress (2 full boxes) for each point of harm against a dangerous foe.

When you fail to defend against a foe's attack and face physical harm, you make the *Endure Harm* move (page 91). As part of that move, you reduce your health track by the amount of harm your foe inflicts, per their rank.

If appropriate to the NPC, they can also inflict stress (page 20) equal to their rank when you fail to resist an action which frightens, demoralizes, or rattles you.

Use the *End the Fight* move (page 82), adding your progress against this foe, when you attempt to resolve the combat. To learn more about progress, see page 14.

The ranks for the sample NPCs in this chapter represent a typical individual of that type. For unusually powerful NPCs, increase their rank by one (to a maximum of epic). For less powerful foes, decrease their rank by one (to a minimum of troublesome). You can also adjust the rank of a foe when circumstances give you significant narrative disadvantage or advantage before the fight. See page 208 for more on adjusting challenge ranks.

FEATURES

These are the typical characteristics of appearance and personality for an NPC. They are not universally true, especially within diverse societies such as Ironlanders and the firstborn, but can provide some common impressions as a starting point.

DRIVES

Drives reflect the motivations and instincts of an NPC. For creatures, these are relatively simple: Hunt, eat, defend territory. For intelligent beings, drives are the typical goals and beliefs of their society, but do not represent the complex range of motivations you will encounter. Drives are a starting place, giving you the rough outline of a typical NPC to be fleshed out (or contradicted) appropriate to their role in the fiction.

NPCs who are prominent in your campaign will have more detail. Depending on their role in your story, their drives may support—or conflict with—your own goals. As you discover details about an important NPC, make note of it. Look for opportunities to introduce interesting and surprising backstories and motivations for these characters.

TACTICS

Tactics provide a reference for how an NPC might act in combat. These give you a sense of typical maneuvers, but do not represent the possibilities of a complex and dramatic combat scene. You should let NPC actions flow out of the fiction. What is the situation? What is their goal? What will add to the excitement and danger of this moment? Make it happen. When in doubt, *Ask the Oracle*.

Your foes should do more than simply try to inflict harm. A fearsome roar or demoralizing boast might cause you to *Endure Stress*. Tactical maneuvers reduce your momentum. Fictional complications—the appearance of new foes, putting companions or allies at risk, or a realization that undermines your quest—will heighten the drama of the scene.

QUEST STARTER

All NPCs include a quest starter, which can serve as inspiration for one of your vows.

YOUR TRUTH

Some NPCs include a question for you to answer. This is an opportunity to customize the NPC to your vision of the Ironlands. You can do this as you define your world or discover through play. Truths may represent an absolute fact, or merely something the people of your world believe.

NPC PACKS

When you fight a group of **troublesome** or **dangerous** foes, you may combine them into a single progress track. This is called a **pack**. It's more convenient than tracking progress for each individual foe, and the scene will move faster.

When you group foes into a pack, increase their rank to represent their combined ability to inflict and resist harm. For a small pack (about 3 to 5), increase the rank by one. For a large pack (about 6 to 10) increase the rank by two. For example, a pack of 4 troublesome foes are treated as a single dangerous foe. If you are facing more than 10 troublesome or dangerous foes, you can group them into smaller packs and associated progress tracks.

When you inflict harm on the pack, you can envision it as appropriate to the fiction. You might wound them, put one or more of them out of action, or drive some back. When you successfully *End the Fight*, you have defeated the last of them, or broken their fighting spirit.

Formidable, extreme, and epic foes may not be grouped into a pack. Each must have its own progress track.

JOINING FORCES WITH NPCs

If your story leads you to cooperating with helper NPCs to overcome challenges, you need to consider how they impact the fiction and your moves. NPCs—unless they are a companion asset (page 39)—won't give you mechanical bonuses on your moves. They also won't make moves of their own. They are simply a part of your story, perhaps impacting the moves you make, the results of those moves, and the rank of your challenges. Gaining the aid of an important NPC might also allow you to *Reach a Milestone* (page 100).

For example:

- If you are charged with protecting NPCs, they might be placed in danger or suffer losses as a result of your failures on moves.
- If you are fighting alongside NPCs, you can reduce the rank of your foes. For example, battling alone against a large pack of raiders might be an extreme challenge. If you are aided by a stalwart band of villagers, you could shift the enemies' rank to formidable.
- If you are being led by an experienced scout, you might choose to skip the *Undertake a Journey* move, or reduce the rank of the journey.

- If an NPC leader agrees to support your quest by allowing passage through contested lands, you might *Reach a Milestone* and mark progress.

As with any NPC, you can *Ask the Oracle* to see how a helper NPC responds, how they fare in a challenge, or what they do next. You can make moves to influence them, such as *Compel*. If you develop a strong relationship through your story, or if you *Fulfill Your Vow* in their service, you can choose to *Forge a Bond*.

In short, make them characters, not numbers. Give them personalities. Give them quirks and motivations. Let them impact your story and your quests, for better or worse, but always keep the focus on your character and your allies.

CREATING NPCs

You should create NPCs that fit your version of the Ironlands, enhance your story, and enrich your character's adventures. Use the sample NPCs as a starting place, or start from scratch. Because NPCs don't have mechanical detail, it's easy to bring them to life without advance preparation.

If you face an NPC in combat, give them a rank. If you like, you can also make note of their drives and tactics. Otherwise, their motivations, abilities, and actions are entirely part of your fiction. They may ignore you, aid you, or oppose you. Make moves to resolve your intentions with them as appropriate. Springboard off those moves with new details and complications to flesh out these characters.

For reoccurring NPCs, make note of what you learn of them over time. If you share a bond, mark it down.

IRONLANDERS

Ironlanders are the human inhabitants of these lands. Unless your story emphasizes adventures well outside of the settled regions, the majority of your interactions will be with fellow Ironlanders.

This section covers a few broad categories of Ironlanders. They are not representative of the variety of people and cultures in these lands. When you are forced to fight an Ironlander and need to determine their rank, you can *Ask the Oracle*, or follow these guidelines:

- A common citizen or brute is **troublesome**.
- A trained warrior is **dangerous**.
- A powerful or veteran warrior is **formidable**.

BROKEN

Rank: Troublesome (3 progress per harm; inflicts 1 harm)

Features:

- Crazy eyes
- Painted skin
- Feral screams
- Scavenged clothing and weapons

Drives:

- Show my power
- Share my pain

Tactics:

- Spring from hiding
- Ferocious attacks

Another people sailed to the Ironlands from the Old World long before our kin settled here. Something happened. Something changed them. Whether it was the long struggle in a harsh land, the ravages of war, or the corruption of some dark force, they left their humanity behind and became what we call the broken. Now, they exist only to kill, to destroy.

We fear the broken for their savagery. But, more than this, we fear them as a dark portent of what we might one day become.

Quest Starter: Years ago, an Ironlander child was taken by a broken tribe. Now they are seen living among them. What is your connection to this person? Can they be brought home, or are they forever lost?

COMMON FOLK

Rank: Troublesome (3 progress per harm; inflicts 1 harm)

Traits:

- Diverse looks
- Weary and worried
- Suspicious of strangers

Drives:

- Prepare for the winter
- Protect family

Tactics:

- Desperate defense
- Stand together

Most of us in the Ironlands are common folk. We are farmers, laborers, crafters, sailors, and traders. When trouble comes, we know which way the pointy end goes, and we stand together to protect our homes and kin.

Quest Starter: Two prominent families are at odds. What is the source of the conflict? What is your relationship to them? What danger threatens to destroy their community if they can't put aside their petty squabble?

HUNTER

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Traits:

- Wearing hides and furs to ward away the cold
- Steely gaze
- At home in the woodlands

Drives:

- A clean kill
- Survive the hunt

Tactics:

- Set traps
- Keep to the shadows
- Deadly shot

Hunters face brutal weather, difficult terrain, dangerous animals, and worse. Many never return from their hunts. Others return, but are forever changed.

Quest Starter: A hunter returns to her village, panic-stricken and pleading for help. The rest of her party is still out there. What happened to them?

MYSTIC

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Knowing eyes
- Tattooed skin

Drives:

- Respect the old ways
- Seek the paths of power

Tactics:

- Foresee the intent of my enemies
- Prepare rituals
- Use trickery

Some say you can tell a mystic by looking them in the eye. They walk in two worlds, and their eyes shimmer with that dark reflection of realms beyond our own. We call it the sight. Some hold that darkness in check. Others are consumed by it.

Quest Starter: A mystic returns to their home after a years-long journey. They are changed. What new power or knowledge do now they wield? What do they seek to do with it? Why do you oppose them?

RAIDER

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Geared for war
- Battle fervor

Drives:

- What is theirs will be ours
- Stand with my kin
- Die a glorious death

Tactics:

- Intimidate
- Shield wall
- Burn it down

Raiders survive by seizing what they need from others. Our grain. Our meat. Our animals. Our iron. They'll take it all, and leave us facing the long winter with nothing to sustain us but prayers to indifferent gods.

Quest Starter: You were raised as a raider, born to battle, but long ago left that life. Troubled by your past, you vow to wipe this powerful clan from the Ironlands. How can you defeat them? What will happen when you must face your former shield-kin?

YOUR TRUTH

A large raider clan is known and feared throughout the Ironlands. What is it called? Who leads it?

WARRIOR

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Traits:

- Battle-hardened
- Scarred

Drives:

- The thrill of the fight
- Protect those in my charge
- Survive another day

Tactics:

- Maneuver for advantage
- Find an opening

Some Ironlanders, through strength of arms, set themselves apart from the common rabble. They are trained to fight, or simply born to it. For them, a sword, spear, or axe is as natural a tool as any hammer or spade.

Quest Starter: A legendary warrior, now well past their prime, swears to face a daunting foe in one final battle. What help do they ask of you and why? Who is their enemy?

YOUR TRUTH

Warrior's shields are often emblazoned with meaningful symbols. What are they? Family crests? Animal totems? Mystical sigils? Motifs honoring the nations of the Old World? If you carry a shield, what is painted on yours?

FIRSTBORN

The firstborn lived here long before the humans landed on these shores. The humans, in their arrogance, named this peninsula the Ironlands and called themselves Ironlanders—but the firstborn gave it names of their own in a time beyond the reach of memory.

To determine the role of the firstborn in your setting, see page 128.

ELF

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Large, luminous eyes seen through a wooden mask
- Gray-green skin the texture of dry leaves
- Sonorous voice
- Wielding bow and spear

Drives:

- Protect the wilds
- Drive out trespassers, or see them pay

Tactics:

- Strike from shadow
- Force their surrender
- Turn the forest against them

Elves are strange beings of the forest, seldom seen beyond the ancient woods of the Deep Wilds. They are fiercely protective of their lands and suspicious of humans. Their scouts patrol the borderlands, riding the fearsome mounts we call gaunts (page 148). Others of their kind watch us from the shadow of the deep woods, spears and bow at the ready. Some say elven mystics can bind the animals and beasts of the forest to aid in the defense of the Wilds.

A few warn that the elves are biding their time, readying the attack which will drive us from these lands.

Quest Starter: The leader of an Ironlander community seeks an audience with the elves. For what purpose? Why are you compelled to help?

YOUR TRUTH

Elves conceal their faces behind ornate wooden masks. What do these masks signify?

GIANT

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Dark hair and ruddy skin
- Twice the size of a tall human, or more
- Wearing layers of wool, hide, and furs
- Stoic and observant

Drives:

- Survive the winter
- Protect the herd

Tactics:

- Fight as a last resort
- Sweeping strike
- Make them flee

Giants dwell in the Tempest Hills and Veiled Mountains. They live a nomadic life alone or in small family units, herding oxen, mountain goats, and sheep. In their own language they are called the Jokul.

Many Ironlanders misinterpret their quiet nature for dullness, but giants are keenly intelligent and observant. They have a great respect for life, even for our kind, and use trickery and negotiation to avoid fights. When they are left without other options, an enraged giant is a devastating, relentless force.

Quest Starter: A pair of giants are raiding human settlements, stealing supplies and livestock. With winter coming, the survival of those settlements is threatened. What is driving the giants down from the hills?

YOUR TRUTH

Every fifth spring, the giant clans meet for a gathering. There, the memory-keepers sing of a great giant hero, revered by all. Who is this hero?

PRIMORDIAL

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Personification of the natural world
- Turbulent, changing visage
- Vaguely human-like or animal-like form

Drives:

- Embody chaos
- Cling to vestiges of power

Tactics:

- Control the elements
- Destroy with primal rage

The primordials, said to be the vestigial spirits of long-forgotten gods, are the most ancient of the firstborn. Each embodies some aspect of the natural world, bound in a crude mimicry of a human or large animal. A river primordial is a mass of rock, gravel, and flowing water. A forest primordial is formed of wood, earth, rocks, and plants. A mountain primordial is a lumbering being of glacier stone and ice. A fire primordial, depending on its mood, might take form as embers, ash, and smoke—or as a raging pyre.

They range in size from the height of an Ironlander to half-again as tall as a giant. Rumors persist of primordials who dwell in the deepest parts of the Wilds, or high in the ranges of the Veiled Mountains, who are as tall as an ancient tree. Beyond, some suggest, in the Shattered Wastes, live primordials who tower into the clouds. Is the sound of distant thunder sometimes the footfalls of mountain-sized primordials who dwell beyond the edge of the known world?

Primordials are solitary beings as unpredictable as the natural forces they personify. They might ignore you. They might lurk at a distance, as if observing you. Or, they might attack. They do not speak in any language we can understand. Some suggest they have no intelligence, and are merely a manifestation of the natural world, no different than a winter storm.

How do you kill a primordial? Most scoff at the idea. You are just as likely to kill the rain or the sea. A mystic might tell you to use a weapon imbued with elemental power. Don't trust them. If you see a primordial, keep your distance. Better yet, run.

Quest Starter: In the dead of winter, a fire primordial is razing homes and burning a nearby wood. At night, orange flames light the sky. What can be done to stop this destruction?

TROLL

Rank: Formidable (1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm)

Features:

- Long limbs
- Sunken, beady eyes
- Translucent skin camouflaged to the environment
- Keen sense of smell
- Speaks in gibberish

Drives:

- Find pretty things
- Keep it secret

Tactics:

- Be sneaky
- Bite and claw
- Run and hide

Trolls mostly live in the Flooded Land, but it's not unusual to encounter one in the Hinterlands or even in the southern reaches of the Havens. They are solitary creatures, wary of contact with Ironlanders but likely to attack if scared or provoked.

They move with their back hunched, often skulking on all four gangly limbs. When they stand straight they are much taller than humans—nearly as tall as a giant. Their skin is a sickly pale gray, but they can camouflage themselves by changing it to match their environment.

Trolls collect objects of all sorts, and particularly value Ironlander trinkets. They are tormented by the fear of others stealing their hoard, and are constantly seeking out new, better hiding places. The items are mostly junk to anyone but a troll, but occasionally an object of real value finds its way into the dregs.

Quest Starter: The villagers tolerate the troll who lives nearby because its presence serves to dissuade a greater threat. They even donate items for its hoard, and put up with its occasional thievery. But now, the troll is missing. What is the looming threat the troll helped avert?

VAROU

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Yellow eyes shining in moonlight
- Pointed ears and snout-like face

Drives:

- Take their land
- Defend my kin
- Keep the bloodcall at bay

Tactics:

- Strike at night
- Leap into combat
- Let loose the bloodcall

The varou are humanoid beings who dwell within the Deep Wilds and in the woods of the Hinterlands. Their features are fierce and wolf-like. They are broad-shouldered and a head taller than the average Ironlander. Their long hair is ornately groomed and decorated with beads and other trinkets.

The varou value territory above all things. They often war amongst themselves and against the elves to gain or defend holdings. They mark their claims by carving clan symbols into trees. Only the foolish ignore the warning of these border signs. Several of our settlements—built too close to varou territory—are now abandoned ruins bearing the mark of a victorious varou clan.

Quest Starter: A varou clan has carved their mark into the trees surrounding an Ironlander community, claiming it as their territory. An attack is surely imminent. What will you do to prevent it?

YOUR TRUTH

A young varou receives their keth—a curved dagger—before undergoing a rite of passage. What must they do to take their place among the adults of the clan?

ANIMALS

Animals are the mundane creatures which dwell in the Ironlands. Some animals are native to these lands; others were also common in the Old World.

Most wild animals are skittish and do not pose a threat to humans. Those creatures have no rank, and can be attacked or interacted with using appropriate moves. For example, *Resupply* (page 63) can represent hunting for deer or small game.

A few notable exceptions—predators, aggressive creatures, and animals trained to fight—are noted here.

BEAR

Rank: Formidable (1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm)

Features:

- Fearsome teeth and claws
- Thick hide

Drives:

- Find food
- Defend cubs

Tactics:

- Roar
- Pin down
- Maul with savage force

Most bears are not aggressive. They avoid Ironlanders and are unlikely to attack unless they see you as a threat.

There are exceptions. The silver bears of the Veiled Mountains, which sometimes range as far south as the Tempest Hills, are territorial, powerful, and aggressive. Likewise, the ash bear, encountered in woodlands throughout the Ironlands, is known for its ferocity and cunning. If either catch your scent, they are likely to hunt you down and attack.

Quest Starter: A group of hunters felled a large ash bear with several arrows. It tumbled into a river and was swept away. Unfortunately, the bear they thought dead is now stalking the group as they make their way back home.

BOAR

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Wiry coat
- Long tusks
- Vicious

Drives:

- Forage
- Protect territory
- Defend sows

Tactics:

- Charge and gore
- Circle and attack again

In the Old World, wild boars were belligerent and dangerous animals. Here in the Ironlands? They are even bigger and meaner. They attack without warning or provocation. They will run you down, gore you, bite you, and circle around to do it all again. And again. And again.

Quest Starter: A boar hunt ends in tragedy when an Ironlander is gored and grievously wounded. How do you know this person? What terrible truth do they reveal as they lay dying?

GAUNT

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Horse-like creature with a lean, skeletal frame
- Ghostly pale eyes
- Black, scaled hide

Drives:

- Run like the wind

Tactics:

- Rear up
- Charge
- Trample

A gaunt is a creature unique to the Ironlands. They maneuver across the rough, dense terrain of the Deep Wilds and Hinterlands with uncanny speed and grace. This makes them ideal as mounts for the elves (page 142), who breed and train them.

A gaunt will not usually act aggressively without provocation, but they are as deadly as the fiercest warhorse under the command of a talented rider.

Quest Starter: Villages in the Hinterlands have fallen prey to a large band of gaunt-riding elves. They attack with sudden and violent force, and are gone before any sort of defense can be mustered. Their leader, a warrior of unmatched skill, rides a distinctive white gaunt. What has driven these elves to strike out against the Ironlanders?

YOUR TRUTH

Some gaunts live in wild herds. They once roamed the wilds in countless numbers, but few now remain. What has happened to thin these herds so dramatically?

MARSH RAT

Rank: Troublesome (3 progress per harm; inflicts 1 harm)

Features:

- Beady eyes
- Long tail

Drives:

- Eat everything
- Breed

Tactics:

- Swarm and bite

The marsh rat is a rodent of unusual size. They are all-too-common in the Flooded Lands or in wetlands within the Hinterlands and Deep Wilds.

They eat almost anything, including carrion and waste. Our grain stores and pantries are an easy target for marsh rats, who dig tunnels or chew through walls to get at the food. They will also try to make a meal out of living prey—deer, cattle, or even an unlucky Ironlander. A pack of marsh rats can kill a horse and reduce it to bone in a matter of hours.

Quest Starter: Marsh rats raided the stores of an isolated settlement. How will you ensure the Ironlanders have enough food to survive the coming winter?

WOLF

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

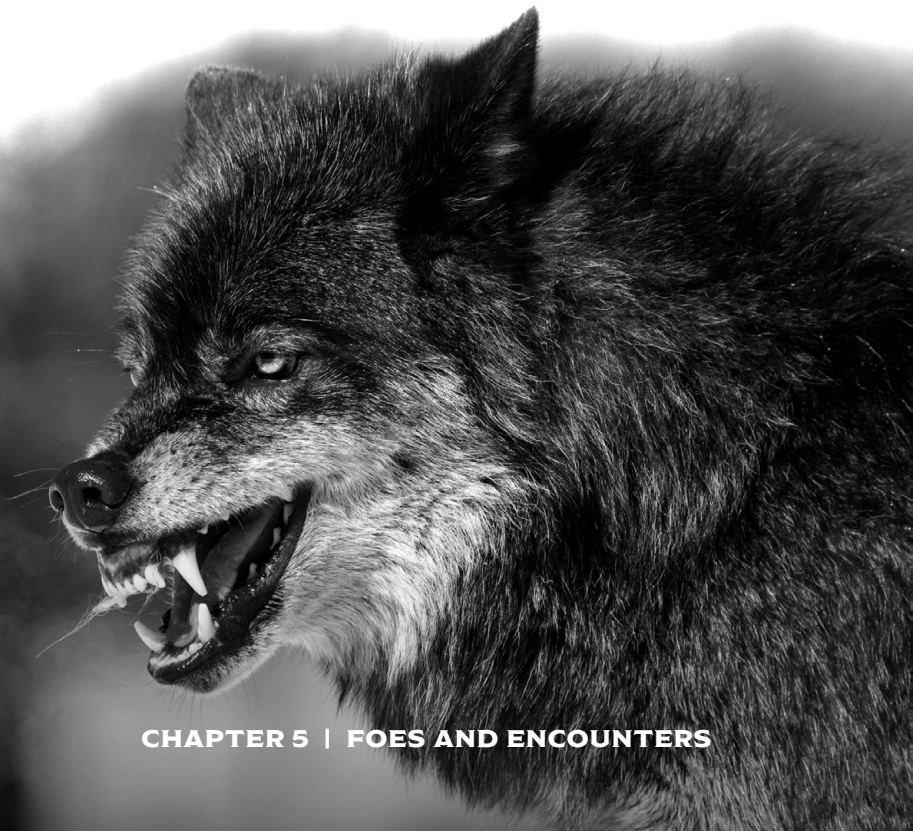
Features: • Keen senses

Drives: • Fight rivals
• Mark territory
• Run with the pack

Tactics: • Stalk
• Pack rush
• Drag to the ground

The Ironlands are home to several breeds of wolves. Most are not aggressive and stay clear of settlements and travelers. Despite that, attacks against Ironlanders are not unknown. A harsh winter and insufficient prey can drive a pack to hunt livestock or even an unwary Ironlander. As night falls we hear their howls, and hope they are well fed.

Quest Starter: You find the grisly remains of a pack of wolves. All are dead, even the cubs. What caused this? Why is it a harbinger of a greater danger?



BEASTS

Beasts are monstrous creatures of great size and power. They are natural beings—not supernatural entities—but were unknown in the Old World.

To determine the role of beasts in your version of the Ironlands, see page 128.

BASILISK

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Giant snake
- Dull yellow-brown skin
- Vibrant yellow eyes

Drives:

- Devour

Tactics:

- Lay in wait
- Mesmerizing gaze
- Sudden bite
- Crush

Basilisks dwell in the Flooded Lands, lurking in the murky waters of the swamps or within marshy thickets. There, they wait patiently for prey. They regularly feed on marsh rats or deer, but will eagerly make a meal out of a passing Ironlander.

Quest Starter: The adventurer set out to slay a basilisk, only to become its next meal. Because the serpent digests its prey slowly, the remains of the adventurer are still undoubtedly within the beast—along with the heirloom sword he wielded. What is your relationship to this person? Why is recovering the sword so important to you?

YOUR TRUTH

Some piece of a basilisk anatomy is prized by the Ironlanders. What is it? How is it used?

ELDER BEAST

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features: • Twice the size of their common kin, or more

Drives: • Dominate
• Protect territory

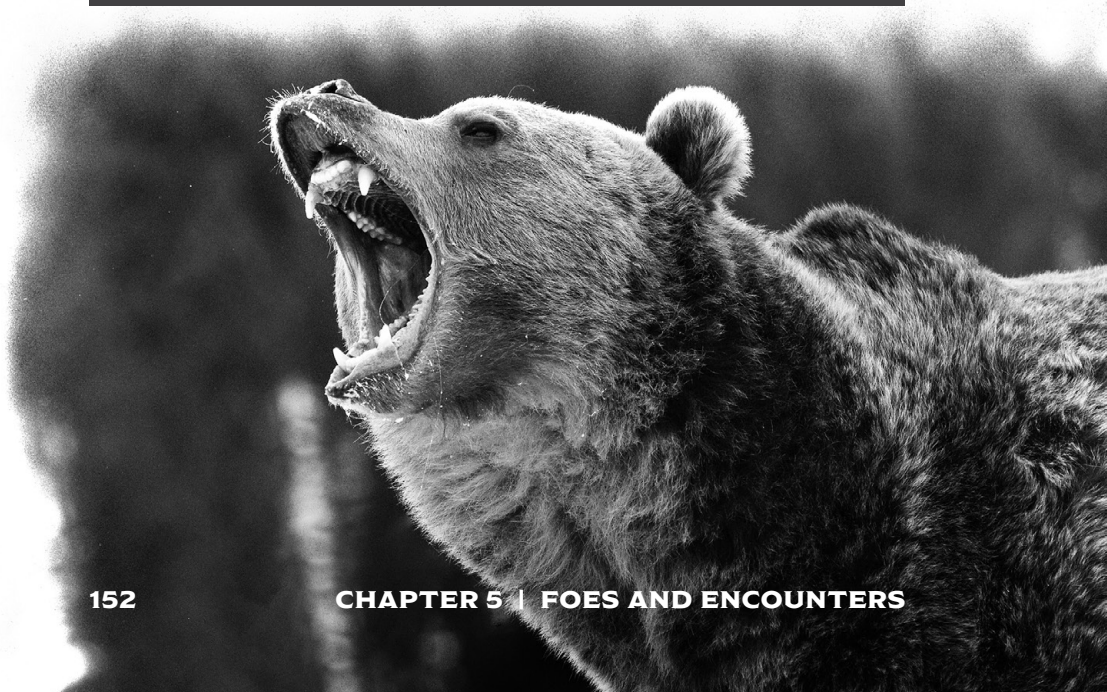
Tactics: • Intimidating display
• Overwhelming attack

Elder beasts—including wolves, bears, and boars—are huge, monstrous versions of their common kin. They are primarily solitary creatures, though elder wolves have been known to lead a pack of normal wolves. Some call them guardians, avatars of the land itself, and say they are as long-lived as the oldest trees.

Quest Starter: An elder wolf, white as snow, appears to you in a dream. When you wake, the memory of its piercing gaze lingers. Is the vision a dark portent or a promise? Why are you compelled to seek this beast out?

YOUR TRUTH

What people of the Ironlands revere and protect the elder beasts?
What group hunts them and why?



HARROW SPIDER

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Massive fangs
- Long legs and bloated body
- Eight iridescent black eyes

Drives:

- Lurk
- Feed

Tactics:

- Drop atop prey
- Bite with pincers
- Trap in webbing

These gigantic creatures are a menace in woodlands throughout the Ironlands. Despite their size, they move through high branches with uncanny grace, dropping suddenly to grapple their prey and entomb them in webbing.

Quest Starter: A brood of harrow spiders attacked a contingent of Ironlanders. The single survivor tells of the horrifying encounter and the monstrous brood mother—a harrow spider larger and stronger than a warhorse. What was this group's mission? What important item are you sworn to recover from one of the victims?



LEVIATHAN

Rank: Epic (1 tick per harm; inflicts 5 harm)

Features:

- Massive bulk
- Flesh as tough as iron
- Cold black eyes
- Sinuous grace

Drives:

- Slumber in the depths
- Destroy those who trespass

Tactics:

- Rise from the depths
- Ram and swamp ships
- Devour prey whole

These massive sea beasts lurk in the darkness of the deepest fjords and in the abyssal depths beyond the Barrier Islands. They sometimes surface to hunt within shallower waters. They will indiscriminately destroy any Ironlander vessel which strays too close to their hunting grounds.

Watchful sailors might catch sight of a leviathan circling their boat, studying them, in the moments before it attacks. Their dagger-shaped head is as tough and destructive as any battering ram, able to shatter a ship in a single blow.

Quest Starter: A leviathan lurks off the coast, preying on fishing boats and trade ships. Among the dead is someone important to you. Who is it? You have vowed to send this beast back to the depths, but doing so will require a mythic weapon—The Abyssal Harpoon, an Old World artifact said to be carved from the bones of a long-dead sea god. Where is this weapon rumored to be held?

YOUR TRUTH

Some coastal people believe leviathans are a manifestation of an ancient spirit. What is it?

MAMMOTH

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Woolly fur
- Large head and curved tusks
- Prehensile trunk

Drives:

- Migrate to fertile ground
- Forage for food
- Protect the young of the herd

Tactics:

- Form a protective circle
- Charge
- Trample
- Gore

These beasts resemble the elephants of the Old World's southern realms, but are larger and covered in a coat of thick fur. They travel in herds among the Tempest Hills, migrating south with the winter and north with the spring. They are not aggressive creatures, but are fearless and will fight to the death to protect their young.

A herd of mammoths is an amazing and humbling sight, but smart Ironlanders keep their distance and stay downwind.

Quest Starter: A mammoth calf wanders alone into an Ironlander settlement. Why do you swear to reunite it with its herd?



WYVERN

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Huge, bat-like wings
- Rows of knife-sized teeth
- Thick hide with a metallic sheen
- Long tail

Drives:

- Watch for prey from high above
- Feed

Tactics:

- Swoop down
- Snap up prey
- Fearsome roar
- Bash with tail

There are several breeds of wyverns in the Ironlands. To the west, tawny wyverns nest in the cliffs of the Barrier Islands and Ragged Coast, diving for fish in the surrounding waters. Inland, the verdant wyverns dwell in forested regions. The largest and most fearsome breed, the iron wyverns, hunt among the Tempest Hills and along the flanks of the Veiled Mountains.

All wyverns have wolfish heads with wide jaws, thick bodies, and sinuous tails. They have short hind limbs and elongated forelimbs which extend along their wings. In flight, they are a terrifying but awe-inspiring creature. On the ground, they lumber heavily on all four limbs, their wings folded back, jaws agape, gaze fixed on their prey. They are the grim cruelty of the Ironlands given form. They are death.

Quest Starter: Ancient cave paintings in the Tempest Hills show humanoids riding atop wyverns. Perhaps these beasts can be tamed. Why are you obsessed with this possibility?

YOUR TRUTH

Rumors persist of a wyvern graveyard where wyverns instinctively go when their death is near. Where is this supposedly located? In what way do Ironlanders make use of wyvern bones?

HORRORS

Horrors are supernatural entities. In the Old World, they were superstition and legend. Here, they are nightmares made real. The Ironlands is fertile ground for darkness and evil to take hold, spawning these undead beings of pure vengeance or mindless hate.

Many horrors can be temporarily defeated through physical attacks, but cannot be killed. They are beyond death.

To determine the role of horrors in your setting, see page 129.

BONEWALKER

Rank: Dangerous (2 progress per harm; inflicts 2 harm)

Features:

- Skeletal corpse
- Yellowed bones
- Tattered remains of clothing and armor

Drives:

- Destroy life

Tactics:

- Rush with unexpected speed
- Attack with the weapons they bore in life
- Grasp and claw

Bonewalkers are human remains given unnatural life. The source of the dark energy animating them is a mystery. Some say it is the will of dark gods. Others say an ancient evil permeates this land and seeps into porous bones of the dead. Or, perhaps it is the work of corrupt mystics.

Bonewalkers usually roam the location of their final resting place—a burial site, a cursed battlefield, or a settlement blighted by disease or violence. Nothing remains of their previous selves. They are soulless monsters driven only to destroy the living.

Quest Starter: A horde of bonewalkers marches relentlessly towards the Havens. What dark force has gathered this army of the undead? How will you stop them?

CHIMERA

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Shambling mass of dead creatures and offal
- Rotting stench

Drives:

- Insatiable hunger

Tactics:

- Horrifying wail
- Relentless assault
- Claw, bite and rend

A chimera is the corrupted form of dead animal flesh given horrible life. Its body is a collection of various creatures, fused together into a twisted, massive entity which knows only pain and hunger. When a dozen blood-tinged eyes focus on you, when its gibbering mouths open at once to scream, your only hope is a quick death.

Quest Starter: Multiple chimera have spawned from the heart of a deep wood. What evil is at work there?

FROSTBOUND

Rank: Formidable (1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm)

Features:

- Mummified, desiccated flesh
- Frozen blue eyes
- A sorrowful, hollow scream

Drives:

- Absorb the warmth of the living

Tactics:

- Sense heat
- Life-draining grasp

Some who fall prey to the long winters or the wild storms of the northern regions are given a horrible new life as the frostbound. These animated corpses are cursed to forever seek out the warmth their death took from them.

Quest Starter: A group of frostbound lurk along a mountain trail. This path is the only safe route to the lowlands from a mining village.

YOUR TRUTH

Can creatures other than Ironlanders become frostbound? If so, undeath gives them uncanny strength. Make them one rank higher than their living form.

HAUNT

Rank: Formidable (1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm)

Features:

- Subtle, unsettling manifestations
- Appear as they did in life
- Lay bare the ravages of death
- Stench of the grave

Drives:

- Torment the living
- Find rest

Tactics:

- Vanish and reappear
- Horrifying visage
- Unleash chaos

Haunts are restless spirits bound to this world by a traumatic or unjust death. They may be tied to a location, an object, or even a person.

A haunt who manifests as a physical being can be dispelled by overcoming them in a fight, but only temporarily. They will only be at peace when their death is avenged or resolved. Some say a haunt can be banished through a ritual, but few possess the knowledge.

Quest Starter: You are plagued by a haunt. Who is it? What do they want of you?

YOUR TRUTH

When someone dies a violent death, or at the hand of another, they are often laid to rest using a specific, ceremonial rite. This, it is believed, prevents them from returning as a haunt. What is this ritual? What rare material is required?

HOLLOW

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Vaguely humanoid shape formed of earth, plants, and insects
- Empty black eyes behind an elven mask
- Smells of wet soil and dead things

Drives:

- See justice done

Tactics:

- Bash with savage strength
- Draw in a whirlwind of materials to reform and enlarge
- Envelop and suffocate

It is said that elves who die an unjust death or have cause to seek retribution can rise as a hollow. Their form is a rippling mass of dead leaves, plants, soil, carrion, and insects. They move with a nightmarish, shambling gait. Their face is the wooden mask they wore in life. Their voice is the rattle of the wind through dry leaves.

As with haunts, they can be temporarily defeated but cannot be killed by physical means. They are a relentless force, bound to this world by a singular motivation—vengeance.

Quest Starter: A hollow terrorizes an Ironlander village. What does it seek? What will you do to stop it?

YOUR TRUTH

How do elven communities view a risen hollow? Are they seen as spirits of righteous vengeance or as dangerous aberrations?

IRON REVENANT

Rank: Extreme (2 ticks per harm; inflicts 4 harm)

Features:

- Empty, patchwork shell of armor and other hunks of metal
- Wielding iron weapons
- A low, reverberating voice

Drives:

- Fulfill the vow
- Destroy any who stand in their way

Tactics:

- Steadfast attacks
- Pull in iron with an unyielding, magnetic force

Some vows are held so fiercely that they survive even after death. An iron revenant is an incorporeal force of furious resolve, the unfinished vow of an Ironsworn given horrible form as a construct of metal.

Attacks may slow them down or temporarily break apart their armored form, but they have no flesh to pierce and cannot be killed. An iron revenant won't stop until their vow is fulfilled.

Quest Starter: Someone you knew has taken form as an iron revenant. Who is it? What is their vow?



SODDEN

Rank: Formidable (1 progress per harm; inflicts 3 harm)

Features:

- Milky eyes
- Mottled flesh

Drives:

- Drown the living

Tactics:

- Draw victims to the water
- Grab and scratch with jagged claws
- Chilling embrace
- Drag into the depths

A sodden is the restless spirit of someone who drowned or was put to rest in water. They can appear in seas, rivers, lakes, ponds, or marshes. Their loneliness and grief compels them to draw living victims into their watery lairs.

A sodden is not confined to its resting place. In fact, some believe that surviving an encounter with a sodden leaves you vulnerable around any body of water until the spirit finishes its work.

Quest Starter: Someone you know died and appears to you as a sodden. Who are they? Can anything be done to put them to rest?

YOUR TRUTH

Many Ironlanders habitually perform a quick ritual when near a body of water, believing it keeps any lurking sodden at bay. What do they do? Is there any truth to this custom?